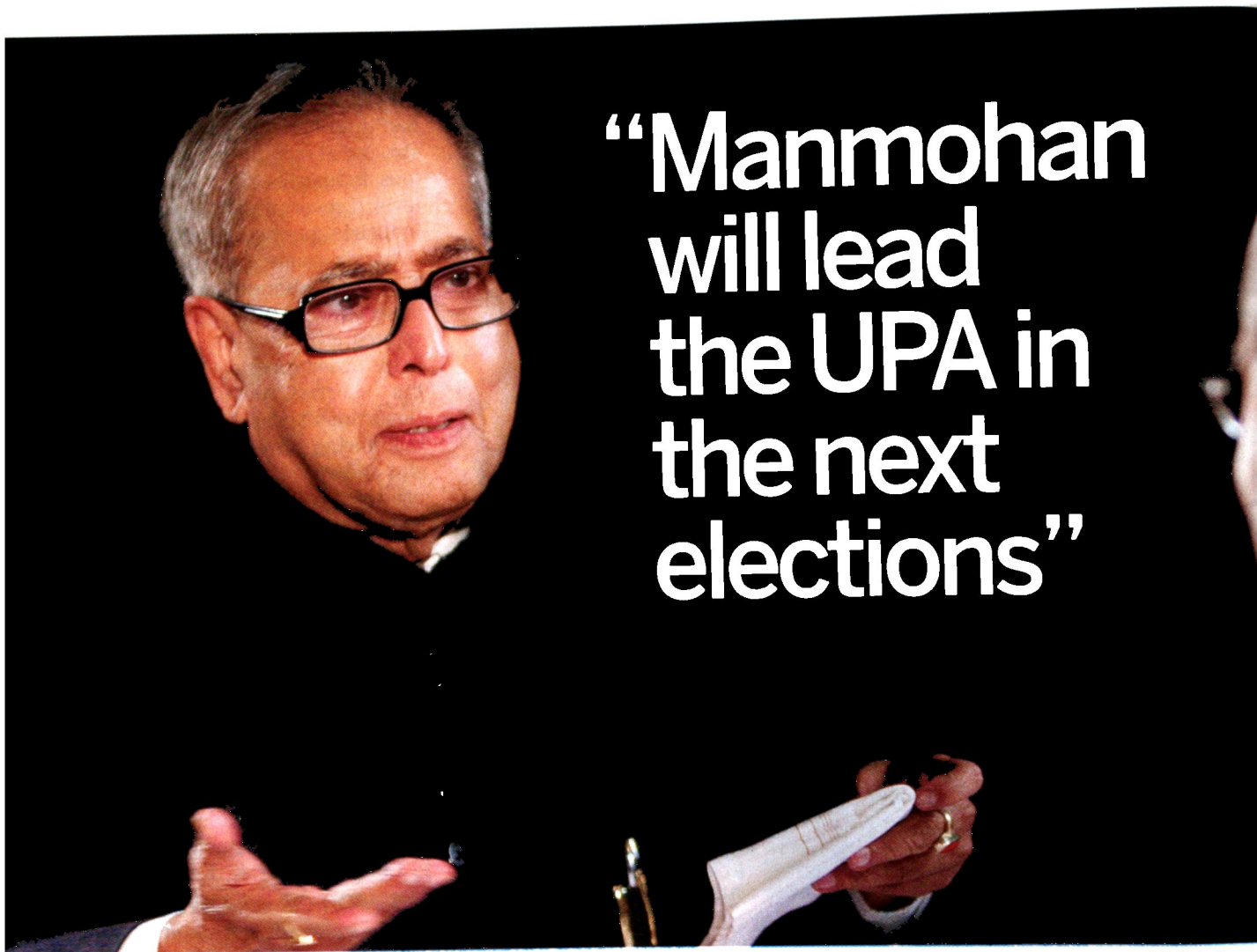




“Manmohan will lead the UPA in the next elections”

HEMANT CHAWLA

In the midst of a busy diplomatic calendar when India is using coercive diplomacy against Pakistan, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee spoke to INDIA TODAY Editor PRABHU CHAWLA for Seedhi Baat on Aaj Tak and Headlines Today. Excerpts from the interview.

Q. Mr Foreign Minister, you have tried coercive diplomacy to isolate Pakistan but it's not working. You seem to have lost the diplomatic war against Pakistan.

A. I do not believe in the use of words like coercion. It is not a diplomatic war, it is diplomacy. The issue here is effective action against terrorism to prevent further outrages and to neutralise and eliminate the infrastructure of terrorism. A definite de-hyphenation of the perpetrators of terror and its victims has to take place. We are doing what every other responsible country would do after a situation like this.

Q. But what is your threshold? Will you wait for another attack to take action?

A. No, this will not happen. You should understand that

diplomacy takes time. It's not a quick-fix method that one has to just switch on or off. Sometimes, it can be a delayed process, but it has to be tested.

Q. Sometimes one feels that you have outsourced your diplomacy to the US and the West.

A. That's not correct. We are telling everybody that you must put pressure on Pakistan as this is not about Indo-Pak relations. These issues need not be seen through the prism of this relationship. In fact, they are a part of global terrorism and should be confronted collectively.

Q. You gave them evidence spanning 40-50 pages. And yet their President says this is merely information.

A. I must tell you candidly that Pakistan has been in denial mode till now. Information is collected on the basis of evidence. When a crime takes place, the first thing that the police records is an FIR. Only after that is the investigation carried out. We have not given them mere information but material from where they can proceed for further investigation. These are tactics to divert attention from the main issue.